

Nowadays, most workhorse notebooks are equipped with combo drives that allow you to back up data and watch DVD movies while travelling

From The Horse's Mouth

"Laptops help people who are on the move"



Neeraj Roy

Neeraj Roy, CEO of Hungama.com, has been a notebook user for the past twelve years, and now uses a Compaq Presario 80XL550. He travels ten days a month on an average, and his laptop is the lifeline that helps him stay connected with work. He feels battery life on the move is the biggest challenge for a notebook user, and is a primary factor in making purchase decisions. He also rates performance and wireless connectivity as important criteria.

Harsh Vardhan Roongta, CEO of Apnaloan.com, is a chartered accountant and has over 18 years of experience in financial services

and consultancy. Roongta has been a notebook user for the past three years. His business trips—twice or thrice a month—see him using his IBM ThinkPad R40e, and a Reliance mobile phone for Internet access. He feels that computing on the move is the best thing in favour of a laptop. Of course, there are a few uncomfortable things to adjust to—the smaller keyboard, for example.

In his opinion, good battery life, a large screen, and ruggedness are the most important criteria when buying a notebook. Performance and weight, he feels, are secondary factors to consider.



H V Roongta

handhelds and mobile phones, notebooks with inbuilt Bluetooth adapters are cropping up. The Acer and Compaq's V1040AP were the only notebooks with inbuilt support for Bluetooth.

With the Centrino platform comes Wi-Fi. Acer and MSI offer the faster 802.11g capable of 54 Mbps, while the rest offered 802.11b adapters capable of reaching 11 Mbps. When put to the test, only MSI's Megabook M510c returned good results, while the Acer was a bit of a letdown.

Hard disk capacities hovered around 40 GB. However, Acer Travelmate 8005LMi outdid the rest by providing an 80 GB hard disk.

Combo drives are standard on workhorse notebooks, and almost every notebook had one, except for the Toshiba Satellite A60 and the Compaq 2514AT—they came with separate DVD and CD-ROM drives. The Acer 8005LMi again excelled by providing a DVD-writer.

A notable feature of the IBM R50 is that it senses movement—if you move the laptop, it locks the hard disk's head to prevent damage to it, just like in the ad you would have seen on TV. The Acer 8005LMi offers a Media bay—a bay that can accept either an optical drive or an additional battery for prolonged life.

Nothing beats the Acer 8005LMi in terms of features; the Compaq V1040AP came second.

Usability

The IBM R50, Toshiba Tecra M2V, Compaq V1040AP and Acer 8005LMi sport sophisticated

design and elegant looks. The MSI M510C, Toshiba Satellite A60, and Zenith's Director and Strategist look good and should attract the younger executives.

The Toshiba Tecra was the lightest and most portable notebook in this category. The MSI, Compaq 2563AI and 2514AT, and the Toshiba Satellite A60 are slightly bulky, but manageable.

The painstaking attention to the ruggedly designed IBM R50 is clear when you notice the grip that helps you lift the upper lid, or the small lamp that helps you find keys in the dark.

Compaq's V1040AP and the Toshiba Tecra take second place in terms of functional design, followed closely by Zenith's Director and Strategist models. The Tecra was slightly better than the Compaq in day-to-day use. The smaller touchpad surface on the Compaq can get really irritating.

Zenith's Director and Strategist were very similar to each other in terms of design and practical usability, except for the 5X's larger proportions.

MSI's M510C closely resembles Apple's iBook design with very few flaws, except for the way too tiny touchpad buttons.

The speakers on almost all these laptops sound dull. Only the Compaq V1040AP's speakers are acceptable, and can add that little extra to your presentation. The MSI's speakers were loud, but lacked depth. The IBM R50's speakers were the worst, but this is the only chink in its armour.

Overall, the IBM R50, Compaq V1040AP and Toshiba Tecra offer the best user experience. The MSI 510C, Zenith's Director and Strategist models, and the BenQ 5000U form the second tier of products in terms of usability.

You get three years' warranty on Acer, BenQ, IBM, and Toshiba Tecra products, whereas Compaq, Zenith and Wipro offer the standard one-year warranty.

Performance

The king on the performance arena was the MSI Megabook M510C. It simply blew the competition away—including the well endowed Acer 8005LMi and Zenith 5X.

In the system test, the Acer won, obviously

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SEPTEMBER 2004



MSI
MegaBook
M510C

Save Power

Battery life is an important aspect of any mobile device—be it a cell phone, PDA or a laptop. Given below are ways in which you can save and prolong battery power:

- ❑ Decrease the brightness of the screen if there's ample light around you.
- ❑ Do not disable processor-specific technologies such as Intel's SpeedStep and AMD's PowerNow technology. These help run processors at lower speeds. Smarter management of CPU cycles enables longer battery life, lower heat dissipation and near-noiseless operation.
- ❑ If your laptop is WiFi and/or Bluetooth-capable, switch these off when not in use. Both are power-hungry and consume a lot of power.
- ❑ Use the Standby mode instead of turning the screensaver on. This mode cuts off power supply to the hard drive and the monitor. Pressing a key or moving the mouse restores the power supply.